that he prostrated himself before the Untouchable and proclaimed him to be his guru.

Manu S. Pillai recounts a legend from the same period: 'The sage Vararuchi, son of Sankaracharya's preceptor, married a pariah (low caste) woman, and fathered twelve children with her. One became a Brahmin, another a carpenter, and one was even a Muslim. Yet another sibling, when they all met for a feast, brought to the table food that he enjoyed: the udder of a cow, or beef if you will. Of course the story goes on to transform the meat into a plant that everyone then consumed, but the lesson is simply that though they were different in what they did and what they ate, they were all born of the same parents, and children of the same land.'[3]

Still, caste discrimination was widespread and iniquitous. Of course Hindus have long accepted the logic of 'reservations' (government legislated quotas in employment and education) in India as a means of making up for millennia of discrimination based on birth. This is why the Constitution inaugurated the world's oldest and farthest-reaching affirmative action programme, guaranteeing Dalits and Adivasis (Scheduled Castes and Tribes) not only equality of opportunity but guaranteed outcomes, with reserved places in educational institutions, government jobs and even seats in Parliament and the state assemblies. Given the appalling discrimination to which they had been subject for millennia—especially those subject to the unspeakable privations of Untouchability—this seems only fair to most, including many caste Hindus, who have not objected to these (SC/ST) reservations.

These reservations are granted to groups listed in Schedules of the Indian Constitution on the basis of their (presumably immutable) caste identities. The addition of the 'Other Backward Classes' (OBC) category in 1989 after the acceptance by the government of Prime Minister V.P. Singh of the recommendations of the Mandal Commission added more people to the numbers benefiting from such official reservations, but it didn't change the basis on which they benefited: despite the 'C' in 'OBC' referring to 'classes', the OBC lists contained castes and sub-castes just above the Dalits in the social pecking order. People like myself tend to disavow caste loyalties as unworthy relics of a more